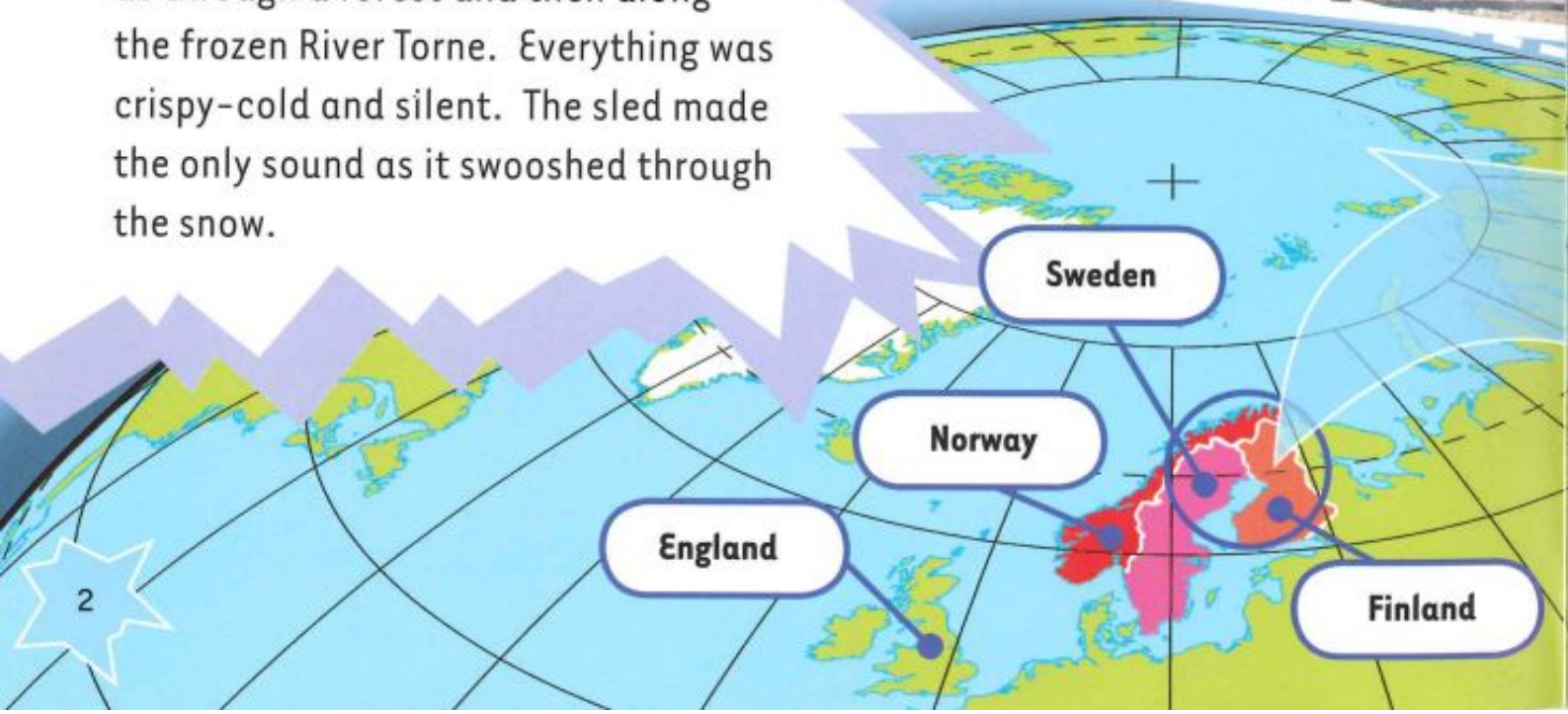
The Ice Hotel

by Gillian Candler

The Ice Hotel – even the name made me shiver. Was it really possible? Could a big hotel be made of ice? I was about to find out.

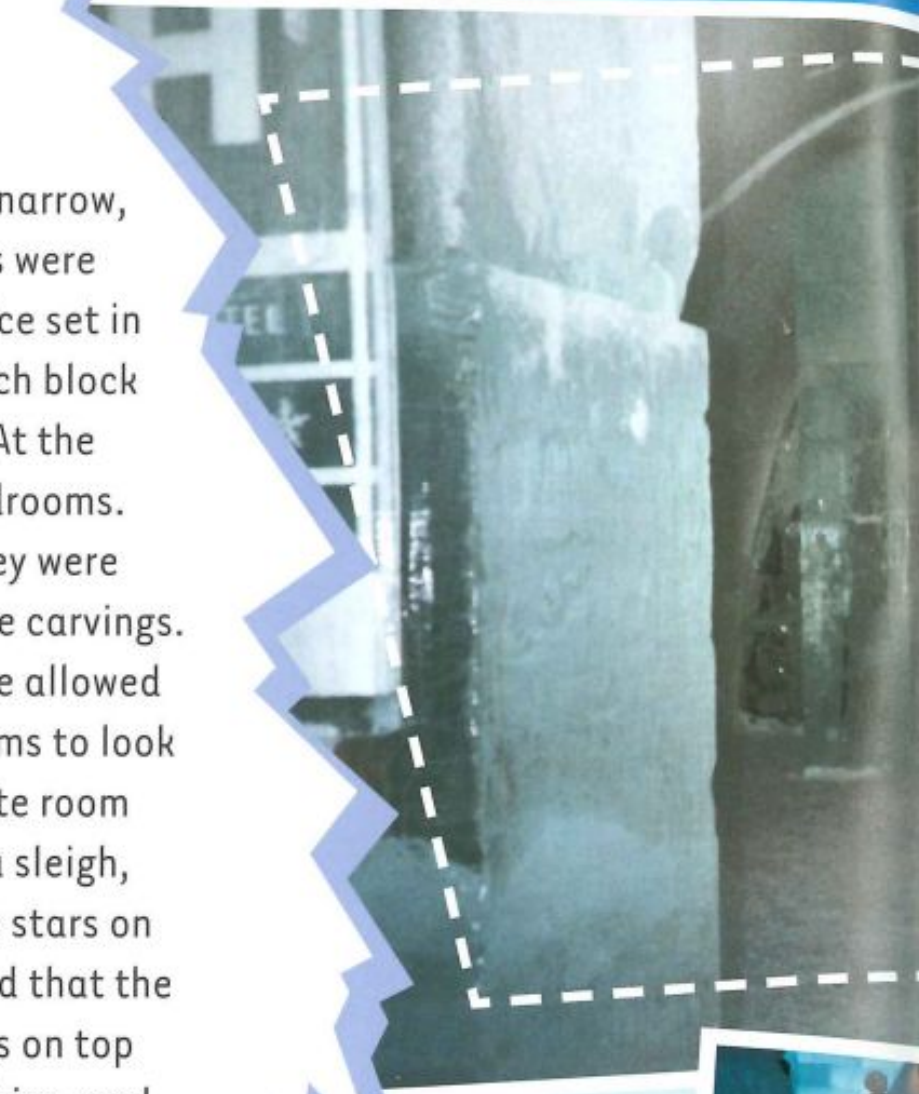
My Swedish friends said I was in for a very special holiday. As we flew to Kiruna, all I could see below was a frosty, white world. The trees were covered with snow, and all the lakes were frozen. From Kiruna, we travelled by dog sled. Fourteen huskies pulled us through a forest and then along the frozen River Torne. Everything was crispy-cold and silent. The sled made the only sound as it swooshed through the snow.

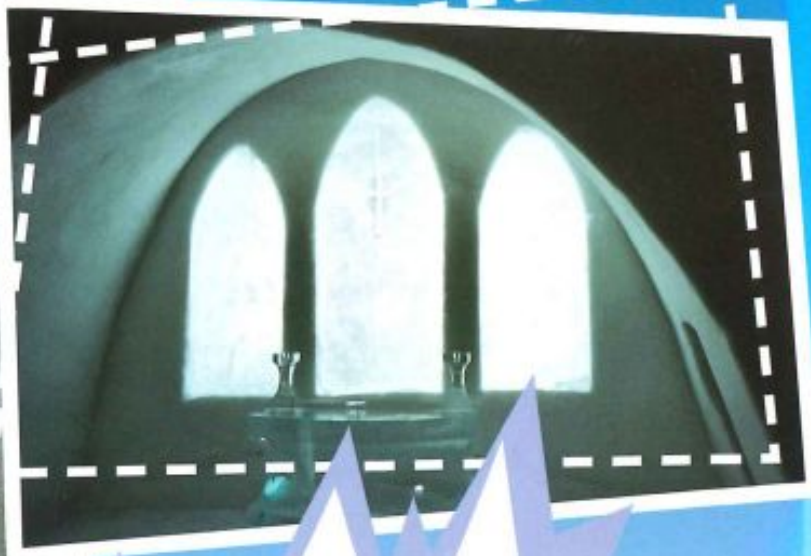


Then we saw it! The hotel looked like the magical home of an ice queen. The big doors were covered with reindeer skin. We reached for the antlers. (That's what the door handles were made from!) As we stepped inside, we saw glistening snow and ice everywhere. Pillars of ice held up the ceiling. The walls and floor were all frosty, and a wall of clear ice at one end of the room let in a ghostly light. The tables, the chairs, and even a chandelier were made of ice.

The hotel was fit for an ice queen, but nobody looked like one! We were dressed in padded overalls, fur-lined boots, gloves, and hats. It was 5 degrees below freezing. Only my face felt cold, though.

First we were taken down a narrow, dimly lit hallway. The lights were made from blocks of clear ice set in the frosty walls. Behind each block was an electric light bulb. At the end of the hall were the bedrooms. Each one was different. They were decorated with beautiful ice carvings. During the day, visitors were allowed to stroll through all the rooms to look at the carvings. My favourite room had an ice bed carved like a sleigh, and tiny lights sparkled like stars on the ceiling. We were pleased that the ice beds had wooden frames on top with mattresses, reindeer skins, and sleeping bags!





Next to the hotel was an ice chapel. The ice windows were beautifully decorated. A cold, white light gleamed through them. The chapel felt as cold as it looked. Brides who get married in the ice chapel need to wear woollen thermals under their dresses!

On the other side of the hotel was an ice bar. There we drank berry juice from glasses made of ice. Coffee would have been warmer, but it's served in paper cups, and I really wanted to sip from an ice glass.

Not everything can be made of ice, though. The restaurant and kitchen are in a heated wooden building. There are no ice toilets or bathrooms, either. We had to step outside to a wooden building to use the bathroom.

How They Build an Ice Hotel

Ice from the River Torne is perfect for building with. It's almost a metre thick, but it's very clear, and it doesn't crack when it's cut. As the river ice freezes, workers from the Ice Hotel sweep snow off the top. This keeps the developing ice as cold as possible, so it's very clear. Big blocks of ice are "harvested" in late winter and kept in a cold store over summer. This means that building can begin in autumn – even though the ice on the river isn't thick enough at that time.

The blocks of ice are used for building the columns that support the roofs of the bigger rooms. To make a column, blocks of ice are stacked on top of each other. The blocks are pasted together with water, which quickly freezes. The clear river ice is also used for the "window walls", which let light through. However, the non-window walls are built in different ways. For example, the walls and curved roofs of the hallways are built over the top of moulds. A mould is placed where a hallway is needed, and then "snice" (a fluffy mixture of snow and ice) is blasted over the mould.

Harvesting ice

Snice is heavy, so it squashes down under its own weight. Eventually it becomes solid ice that's frosty rather than clear. Then a tractor drags the mould out, leaving a tunnel in the ice. The moulds are re-used every year – but they're placed in new positions because every ice hotel is completely different.

Staying in the Ice Hotel was a real adventure. It was cool waking up in an ice bed. We couldn't quite believe where we were. But we didn't stay long in bed. There were too many fun things to do outside!